SPORTS ▼

RAY OF HOPE FOR HOCKEY

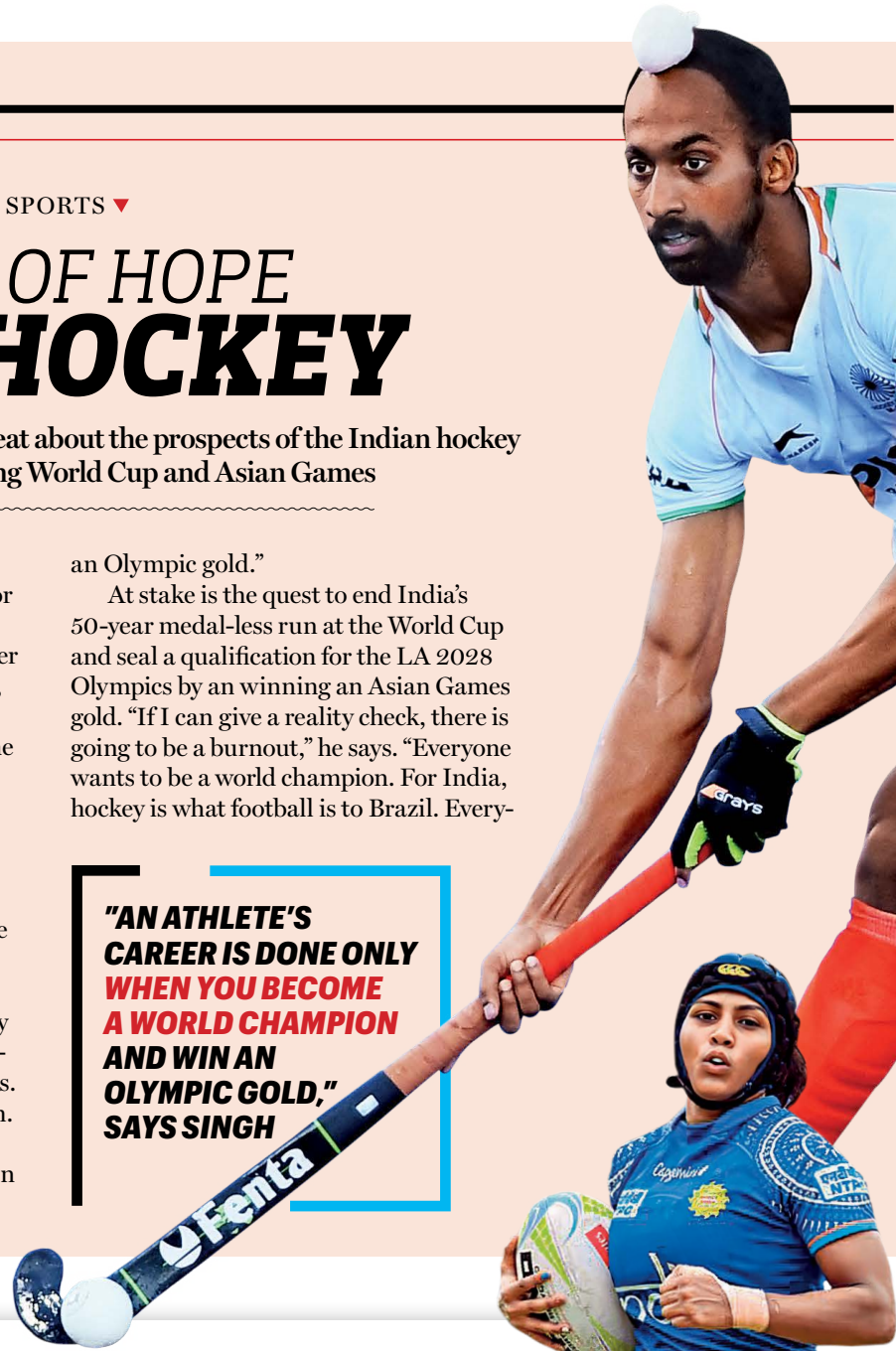
Midfielder Hardik Singh is upbeat about the prospects of the Indian hockey team at the upcoming World Cup and Asian Games

It's been less than a decade since he made his debut with the senior team, but Hardik Singh has already won Hockey India's Player of the Year thrice. Individual accolades, though, don't occupy the 27-year-old who has become a pivotal member of the squad and is seen by many as its future captain. "When there's good, healthy competition within the team, you improve personally," he says.

More prized for Singh are the team's two Olympic bronze medals, the Asian Games gold and Asia Cup title. But Singh is in no mood to rest on his laurels. This year is pivotal, with a busy schedule that sees barely a breather between the World Cup and Asian Games. "We are only halfway there," says Singh. "An athlete's career is done only when you become a World Champion and win an Olympic gold."

At stake is the quest to end India's 50-year medal-less run at the World Cup and seal a qualification for the LA 2028 Olympics by an winning an Asian Games gold. "If I can give a reality check, there is going to be a burnout," he says. "Everyone wants to be a world champion. For India, hockey is what football is to Brazil. Every-

> ***"AN ATHLETE'S CAREER IS DONE ONLY WHEN YOU BECOME A WORLD CHAMPION AND WIN AN OLYMPIC GOLD," SAYS SINGH***



SPORTS ▼

LADIES' LEAGUE

Rugby India's launching of **a women's league is a big win** for gender parity in sport

In just its second year, Rugby India has pulled off a feat that too the BCCI over a decade and still eludes the Kabaddi Federation: It has kick started a women's league. "I have always dreamt of this moment when India's best will be playing with the world's best, but I never gave it a gender," says Rahul Bose, actor, former player and



CHARGE DOWN
(From left) **Bhumika Shukla** (*Mumbai Dreamers*); **Nirmalya Rout** (*Kolkata Banga Tigers*); **Amandeep Kaur** (*Chennai Bulls*)



Shikha Yadav (Delhi Redz) is the highest-paid Indian woman player this season